

Canadian Rockies: a Loop from Vancouver

Fourteen days from Vancouver: the Sea-to-Sky and Duffey Lake roads, Mount Robson and Jasper, the Icefields Parkway to Banff, Kootenay National Park and Radium Hot Springs, the Crowsnest and Highwood Pass, Rogers Pass, the Okanagan wine country, and home over Manning Park. Golf at Vancouver Golf Club, Jasper Park Lodge and Banff Springs.

14 days: 11 riding, 3 golf · **Riding:** about 3,000 km (1,850 mi) · **Start and finish:** Vancouver · **Best:** July to mid-September (Highwood Pass opens June 15) · **Park pass:** Parks Canada Discovery Pass

Arrive Vancouver

Fly into Vancouver and collect the bikes.

Overnight: Vancouver

Day 1 Golf at Vancouver Golf Club

A round at Vancouver Golf Club in Coquitlam, the oldest club in the Lower Mainland (1910) and a host of the Canadian Women's Open. It is a private club, so arrange guest play ahead, through a member or your home club's pro.

Overnight: Vancouver

Day 2 Vancouver to Lillooet

About 250 km (155 mi)

The Sea-to-Sky Highway along Howe Sound to Squamish and Whistler, then Pemberton and the Duffey Lake Road: tight curves, steep grades and glacier-fed lakes, dropping into the dry Fraser Canyon at Lillooet.

By way of: Horseshoe Bay · Squamish · Whistler · Pemberton · Duffey Lake Road

Overnight: Lillooet

Day 3 Lillooet to Clearwater

About 290 km (180 mi)

Highway 99 through Marble Canyon to Cache Creek, east to Kamloops, then north up the North Thompson valley. Wells Gray Park's waterfalls are just north of Clearwater.

By way of: Marble Canyon · Cache Creek · Kamloops · Barriere

Overnight: Clearwater

Day 4 Clearwater to Jasper

About 330 km (205 mi)

North to Valemound, then past Mount Robson, the highest peak in the Canadian Rockies, and over the Yellowhead Pass into Alberta and Jasper.

By way of: Blue River · Valemound · Mount Robson · Yellowhead Pass

Overnight: Jasper

Day 5 Golf at Jasper Park Lodge

A round at Fairmont Jasper Park Lodge, then Maligne Canyon and the Maligne Lake road in the evening, the best time to see wildlife.

Overnight: Jasper

Day 6 Jasper to Banff

About 290 km (180 mi)

The Icefields Parkway: 232 km of glaciers, turquoise lakes and mountain walls. Athabasca Falls, the Columbia Icefield, Peyto Lake and Bow Lake, then Lake Louise, Moraine Lake and the Bow Valley Parkway into Banff.

By way of: Athabasca Falls · Columbia Icefield · Peyto Lake · Bow Lake · Lake Louise · Moraine Lake · Bow Valley Parkway

Overnight: Banff

Day 7 Golf at Banff Springs

A round at the Fairmont Banff Springs course between the Bow River and Mount Rundle. Ride the Lake Minnewanka loop in the evening.

Overnight: Banff

Day 8 Banff to Radium Hot Springs

About 140 km (85 mi)

Over Vermilion Pass on the Continental Divide into Kootenay National Park on Highway 93: Marble Canyon, the Paint Pots, the Kootenay River valley and Sinclair Canyon into Radium. A short day, with the afternoon in the hot pools.

By way of: Castle Junction · Vermilion Pass · Marble Canyon · Paint Pots · Sinclair Canyon

Overnight: Radium Hot Springs

Day 9 Radium Hot Springs to Fernie

About 240 km (150 mi)

South down the Columbia Valley past Invermere and the Columbia Lakes, through Fort Steele's heritage town and Cranbrook, then east up the Elk Valley to Fernie.

By way of: Invermere · Fairmont Hot Springs · Canal Flats · Fort Steele · Cranbrook

Overnight: Fernie

Day 10 Fernie to Canmore over Highwood Pass

About 385 km (240 mi)

Over the Crowsnest Pass into Alberta past the Frank Slide, north up the Cowboy Trail (Highway 22) through ranch country to Longview, then west on Highway 541 and over Highwood Pass, at 2,206 m the highest paved pass in Canada. Down through Kananaskis Country to Canmore.

By way of: Sparwood · Crowsnest Pass · Frank Slide · Cowboy Trail · Longview · Highwood Pass · Kananaskis

Overnight: Canmore

Day 11 Canmore to Revelstoke

About 340 km (210 mi)

West past Lake Louise and over the Kicking Horse Pass through Yoho (Emerald Lake is a short detour), down to Golden, then over Rogers Pass through Glacier National Park to Revelstoke.

By way of: Lake Louise · Kicking Horse Pass · Yoho · Emerald Lake · Golden · Rogers Pass

Overnight: Revelstoke

Day 12 Revelstoke to Kelowna

About 200 km (125 mi)

West along the Eagle River to Sicamous and Shuswap Lake, then south through Vernon and along Kalamalka and Okanagan lakes into Kelowna.

By way of: Eagle Pass · Sicamous · Enderby · Vernon · Kalamalka Lake

Overnight: Kelowna

Day 13 Kelowna to Osoyoos

About 140 km (85 mi)

An easy wine day down the Okanagan: the Naramata Bench above Penticton, then Oliver and the Golden Mile, “the wine capital of Canada”, to Osoyoos at the US border. Leave the tasting until the bike is parked.

By way of: Naramata Bench · Penticton · Okanagan Falls · Oliver · Golden Mile

Overnight: Osoyoos

Day 14 Osoyoos to Vancouver

About 400 km (250 mi)

The Crowsnest Highway west: over Richter Pass, through the Similkameen valley and Princeton, then the curves of Manning Park and down to Hope and the Fraser Valley back to Vancouver.

By way of: Richter Pass · Keremeos · Princeton · Manning Park · Allison Pass · Hope

Overnight: Vancouver

Depart Fly home from Vancouver

Return the bikes and fly home.

Best time to go

- Best: the week after Labour Day (early September) to mid-September. Summer crowds are gone, roads are quieter, and the larches start turning gold by mid-September.
- Good: mid-July to August. Warmest weather and every road open, but the parks are busiest and wildfire smoke is most likely in late July and August.
- Earliest: from June 15, when Highwood Pass opens. Late June can still bring snow on the high passes and cold mornings on the Icefields Parkway.
- Latest: late September. After that, early snow on Rogers Pass and the Icefields Parkway becomes likely, and Highwood Pass closes December 1.

BMW rental in Vancouver

- Cycle BC Rentals & Tours: BMW R 1300 GS, R 1300 GS Adventure, R 1300 RT, F 900 GS and smaller GS models; luggage included (cyclebc.ca)
- AlpenPass Adventures: BMW R 1300 GS and GS Adventure, F 900 GS Adventure; unlimited mileage (alpenpass.ca)
- EagleRider: BMW R 1300 GS and GS Adventure at Vancouver, North Vancouver and the airport (eaglerider.com)
- Ask about kilometre limits and travel into Alberta. This loop is about 3,000 km.

Golf

- Vancouver Golf Club, Coquitlam: private, guest play by arrangement
- Fairmont Jasper Park Lodge
- Fairmont Banff Springs

Riding notes

- Wildlife on the road is the main hazard: elk, deer, bighorn sheep and bears, especially at dawn and dusk.
- Fuel is limited on the Icefields Parkway (only Saskatchewan Crossing) and on Highway 40 over Highwood Pass. Fill up before each.
- Highwood Pass is closed December 1 to June 14.
- Expect cool mornings at altitude even in summer, and wildfire smoke some years.

Park pass

- A Parks Canada Discovery Pass covers Jasper, Banff, Kootenay, Yoho, Glacier and Mount Revelstoke national parks.

Draft route. Distances and times are approximate; check road, pass and ferry conditions before each day.